I'm often asked to summarize the basic attraction of being a professional cricketer. That's hard to put into words, but it has something to do with shared experience. I've literally travelled the world with the likes of Jimmy and Broady. We've laughed a helluva lot, cried occasionally, celebrated and commiserated together. We've even posed naked together, helping to raise awareness of testicular cancer as part of the Everyman Campaign. You don't become family, but you do become extremely close friends. Cricket holds you close, grips you tighter than is sometimes comfortable, because it is a game of emotional contrasts that lasts a long time. I understand the primeval satisfaction of walking off a rugby pitch, battered and bruised, after eighty-odd minutes in the trenches with your mates, but that's an entirely different feeling from sharing a close, hard-fought Test match with a bunch of blokes who are continually on edge.

You feel absolutely drained. I'm mates with Dylan Hartley, the England rugby captain, and he gives me some tap about being in a sport that involves following the sun. To someone involved in brutal, personalized combat, in near-perpetual winter, that seems an attractive alternative. Try batting beneath a helmet for six hours in intense heat. Try putting yourself through a modern bowler's workload. Even fielding for long spells, relatively static but switching concentration on and off, takes it out of you.

The punishment was self-inflicted, but I have never seen someone play through the pain Ben Stokes endured from a succession of ill-fitting boots in Perth during the 2013–14 series. They fell to bits, and he was basically sandpapering his toes. He got through two pairs of protective socks in each session and was scraping his flesh on rock-hard ground during his follow-through. At the end of the day you could almost see bone beneath flayed skin. Obviously, it was excruciating, but you'd have never known it by Stokesy's demeanour. He just got on with it. Having hand-made, specially measured boots, like most internationals, didn't occur to him early in his career. He was the roughest of diamonds, raw and impulsive, biffing the ball all over the place in practice and playing with an almost reckless abandon.

That 2016 series in South Africa was, for him, a landmark of sorts. His 258 off 198 balls in Durban was extraordinary. It was the second-fastest double century in Test history, off 163 balls, and the fastest 250 in history. No England batsman had hit more sixes in one Test innings – eleven. He